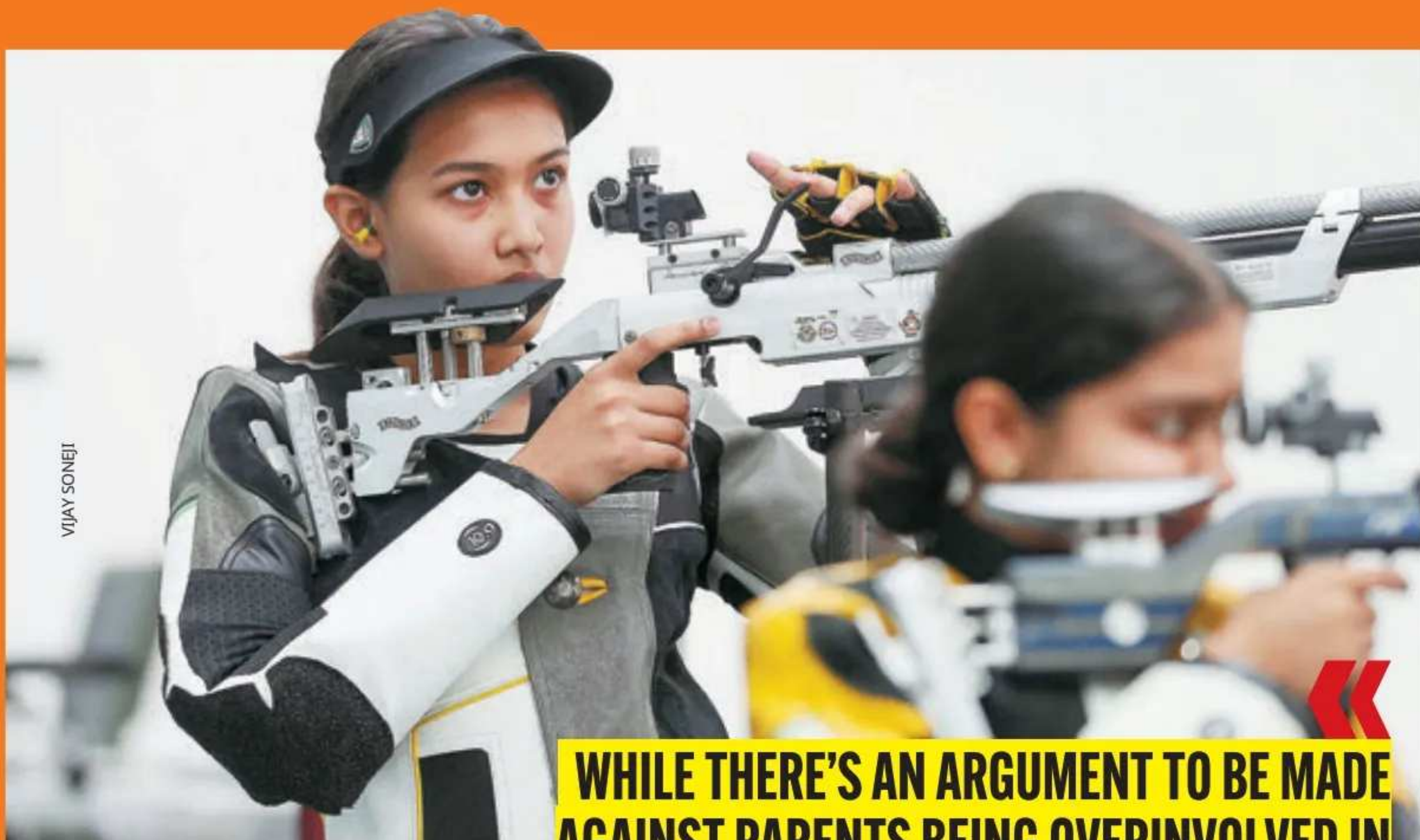




WHILE THERE'S AN ARGUMENT TO BE MADE AGAINST PARENTS BEING OVERINVOLVED IN THEIR CHILDREN'S CAREER, TILOTTAMA SEN'S FATHER, SUJIT, THINKS A BALANCE HAS TO BE MADE

lot more. I've seen a couple of parents come to competitions when their children were juniors, but they stopped coming soon after. Girls generally seem to have more protective parents," says Deepali Deshpande, former chief coach of the Indian shooting team.

Clingy or not, the parents in Bhopal take their job seriously. Their role doesn't just end with dropping their child off. Sujit, who often has to take unpaid leave from his job as a software professional in Bangalore to travel with Tilottama (above), noted down every one of her scores and sent them to himself over WhatsApp. Once he returns to his hotel room, Sen plots the scores on an Excel document, trying to find patterns in her performances.

In the evening, he will sit with her and discuss, among other things, the 9.7 in her third series that kept her already impressive 632.4 qualifying score from being even higher. He'll also dole out performance-based rewards. "After every competition or training round, I usually motivate her by rewarding her for her good scores. For every 10.8 shot, I give her 20 rupees, and for every 10.9 shot, I give her 25 rupees. If she crosses 635 in qualification, it's a bonus of 100 rupees," says Sen.

While there's an argument to be made against parents being overly involved in their children's careers, Sen thinks a balance has to be struck.

"At the end of the day, when a coach is working with so many athletes, there's no guarantee that they are going to be able to give their undivided attention to an athlete. This is especially true for younger shooters, who lack the maturity to know when they need to stand their ground against a coach. At last year's World Cup in Bhopal, Tilottama was told by a coach to tinker with her rifle in order to experiment with its settings. It proved to be a disaster, but she couldn't have said no to her coach. **Sometimes you need a family member to be able to put their foot down.** Tilottama is only 16. Once she gets older, she will have more confidence to be able to make her own decisions. I'll happily step away

then," says Sen.

That's the sort of role Pawandeep Singh sees himself fulfilling as well. "There was no range in Faridkot when Sift started her career. I run a rice mill and have no knowledge of shooting. But because I had to travel with Sift whenever she trained and then whenever she travelled for a competition, I understood a fair amount myself. **Now my role is to sometimes serve as an intermediary between Sift and her coaches,**" he says.

Not all parents who travelled to Bhopal felt the need to be as involved with their child. "My job is just to be by Manu's side. When it comes to shooting, what can I actually say that Jaspal sir doesn't already know?" Sumedha says.

The same is true for Sift's mother, Ramneek Kaur, as well. "My job is simply to keep Sift as relaxed as possible so that she is not stressed outside shooting. She has her own